Contact research participants where applicable, & keep field notes: jot down your observations & experiences; transcribe material from conversations; make sure you're aware of your biases; what are you interpreting versus what are you docume1

Project 2
Process Worksheet 2: Critical & Empirical Research

This process worksheet is the heart of your research. It consists of two parts. We will work on the first part in class on March 2 (critical research). You will work on the second part (empirical research) on March 4 outside of class (instead of coming to class). You must finish both parts 1 & 2 by March 6, 1159 PM EST. Choose one person from your group to email me your worksheet. Send to khanzali@syr.edu

PREWRITE
(We will do this in class on March 2)

"I have found that if you work on your skills–your capacity to see and hear others–you really can get a sense of another person's perspective."
-D. Brooks, How to Know a Person, P. 121

Read the epigram above. Is research a way to "see and hear" others? Can we improve our "capacity" to see and hear others by doing good research? What does "good research" mean to you? What is the connection between Brooks' claim and your understanding of research?

PART 1: CRITICAL RESEARCH
Seeing and Hearing Stakeholders
Work on in class March 2, It is Due on March 6 @1159 PM EST

Stakeholders are institutions/people/groups who have a stake or investment in an issue of political/social importance. For example, when SNAP funding was cut in the fall, the stakeholders included: impoverished families, mothers, children, politicians, social service agencies, taxpayers, grocery stores, people who work at grocery stores.

For this part of your process worksheet, Gather 3 primary or secondary using web-based research methods that shed light on the various stakeholders who are part of the hard conversation that you're joining. Using any of the Library Research Tools , learn about their viewpoints and jot them down in the space provided. Specifically:

1. Name/Group/Affiliation: College students who use AI tools for studying

- What is their place in the power hierarchy of this hard conversation? What is their life circumstance?

Students have less institutional power than professors and administrators but are directly affected by AI policies.

- How are they impacted by the issue? What stake do they have in it? What do they stand to lose if they don't win?

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AI tools help students brainstorm ideas, understand difficult concepts, and improve writing. If AI is banned, students lose access to a useful learning tool.

- What's their opinion? What have they said? Include key quotes.

Students say AI can help them understand difficult topics but believe they still need to question the accuracy of AI responses.

"Many students say AI can be helpful for studying, but they also believe they must learn how to question the information AI provides."

- How do they see the issue? What is the problem as they see it? (Keep in mind, Brooks' point: "How you see a situation depends on what you are capable of doing in a situation")

Students often see the problem as misuse of AI rather than the technology itself.

- What's one thing from the Library Research Tools doc that you used to find this information?

Used Google Scholar and searched "student perspectives AI in education".

- Add a link to the source.

https://www.npr.org/2026/03/06/nx-s1-5732793/college-student-perspective-using-ai-in-class#:~:text=A%202025%20Harvard%20University%20study,must%20learn%20to%20question%20them.

2. Name/Group/Affiliation: Students concerned about AI misuse

- What is their place in the power hierarchy of this hard conversation? What is their life circumstance?

Students have less power than professors and universities when it comes to making rules about AI in school. They are focused on learning, completing assignments, and getting good grades.

- How are they impacted by the issue? What stake do they have in it? What do they stand to lose if they don't win?

Students are directly affected by how AI is used in education. Some worry that if AI is used too much, it could make school unfair or reduce real learning. They may lose the value of their own work if others rely too much on AI.

- What's their opinion? What have they said? Include key quotes.

Some students believe AI should be used carefully and that people should question the answers AI gives. "Students must learn to question AI-generated answers."

- How do they see the issue? What is the problem as they see it? (Keep in mind, Brooks' point: "How you see a situation depends on what you are capable of doing in a situation")

They see the problem as people relying too much on AI instead of learning and thinking for themselves.

- What's one thing from the Library Research Tools doc that you used to find this information?

Google Scholar

- Add a link to the source.

https://www.npr.org/2026/03/06/nx-s1-5732793/college-student-perspective-using-ai-in-class

- Is the source, website, etc. credible & relevant? Explain

Yes. NPR is a trusted news organization and the article talks about college students' views on AI in education, which is relevant to this topic.

3. Name/Group/Affiliation: professors and teachers

- What is their place in the power hierarchy of this hard conversation? What is their life circumstance?

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Teachers and professors have more power than students because they create assignments, grade work, and enforce academic rules. Their job is to help students learn and maintain academic standards.

- How are they impacted by the issue? What stake do they have in it? What do they stand to lose if they don't win?

Teachers are impacted because AI tools can make it harder to know if students are doing their own work. If AI is misused, teachers worry that students may rely on it instead of learning the material. They could lose trust in student work and the quality of education.

- What's their opinion? What have they said? Include key quotes.

Some teachers believe AI can help education but should be used carefully. A survey of U.S. educators found that 60% of teachers have used AI in their classrooms, and many believe it can improve learning outcomes.

- How do they see the issue? What is the problem as they see it? (Keep in mind, Brooks' point: "How you see a situation depends on what you are capable of doing in a situation")

Teachers often see the problem as finding a balance between using new technology and making sure students still develop real skills like writing and critical thinking.

- What's one thing from the Library Research Tools doc that you used to find this information?

Google Scholar / online education news search

- Add a link to the source.

https://www.forbes.com/advisor/education/it-and-tech/artificial-intelligence-in-school/

- Is the source, website, etc. credible & relevant? Explain

Yes. Forbes Advisor is a well-known business and education publication that reports on technology and education trends.

4. Now what's your stake? Each partner answer the questions below:

- What are your places in the power hierarchy of this hard conversation? What is your life circumstance?

  I'm currently a student focused on learning, completing assignments, and maintaining good grades, but I'm navigating a new world where AI tools are increasingly available and normalized, but the rules around using them are still unclear or inconsistent across my classes.

  HC - I am a student I am trying to get good grades so I use AI to help me learn sometimes I feel AI helps me learn more than teachers mostly when the class is like the big lecture halls so I use AI as a refresher and a tool to explain concepts but if I still dont understand after using AI I will ask the teachers or a ta for extra help/

- How are you impacted by the issue? What stake do you have in it? What do you stand to lose if they don't win?

  HC - Depending on how AI is seen it can affect my usage of AI say the teacher has a no AI policy it would mean if there is a topic I dont understand I will have to spend extra time with the teacher during office hours to understand but what if the office hours dont fit my schedule i will have to reschedule and do so much more to understand a concept and also teachers arent available 24/7

  As a design student some professors encourage using AI as a tool to expedite the design process, making full renders that would've taken days to complete in under a minute. It helps, but depending on it is not something ideal.

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- What's your opinion? How do you see the issue? What is the problem as you see it? (Keep in mind, Brooks' point: "How you see a situation depends on what you are capable of doing in a situation")

  HC - I believe AI should be used responsibly as a learning tool rather than completely banned. The problem is not the technology itself but how people use it. Students should learn how to use AI ethically without relying on it too much.

  AI is a tool that can genuinely help learning, but only if used intentionally and transparently. The problem isn't the technology—it's that we haven't developed a shared culture of responsible AI use. All involved parties need to agree on what is the right and safe way to use AI. Employers are increasingly looking for people who know how to use AI well. However, this shouldn't mean people with real skills should be left behind in favor of those that can prompt well. There needs to be a balance when using AI, as a tool to help rather than to replace.

Infer Pathos: What are the "emotional undercurrents" of the issue? How do you know? What words are these emotions masked in?
Students who use AI as a helpful tool feel relieved when work is shortened. It makes life a whole lot easier and allows them to focus on other tasks or their personal lives.

HC - The emotions behind this issue are fear, stress, and excitement. Teachers may fear that AI will cause more cheating. Students may feel stress from schoolwork and use AI for help. Some people are excited because AI could help learning.

Synthesize: what are the key differences and similarities you notice among the stakeholders? How are their life experiences different? How do their life experiences compare to your own?

General students rarely experience the consequences of over-reliance. They see only benefits because they haven't yet had to rebuild a skill which they relied on AI to do.

Teachers experience the problem first hand. They see hundreds of students churn out the same chatGPT slop and notice that students aren't actually learning, just handing the task off to a robot. There is gap between AI-generated work and actual learning.

HC - Students and teachers both care about education, but they think about AI differently. Students see AI as a tool that can help them study. Teachers worry that AI could lead to cheating or less learning. Their experiences are different because teachers grade work and students complete assignments. I understand the student side more because I am also a student.

Apply: What is your take on the issue in relation to the stakeholders' perspectives? What stake do you have in the issue? How do your viewpoints compare to each other and to the other stakeholders that you researched?

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HC - I think AI can be useful if it is used the right way. I understand teachers concerns, but I also think AI can help students learn and understand topics better. My stake in this issue is that AI will likely be part of education in the future, so students should learn how to use it responsibly.

Unlike general students who only see the benefits of using AI, I recognize the real risks of AI dependence that cautious students fear. But unlike cautious students who see AI as mainly a threat, I've experienced that it can be genuinely helpful for learning when used right. And unlike teachers who worry about verification and standards, I live with the reality that AI is a genuine helpful tool when used right. The issue isn't AI itself, it's that we haven't built a culture of responsible use around it.

PART 2: EMPIRICAL RESEARCH

You will do this part outside of class on Wednesday, March 4. **We will not meet in class on Wednesday, March 4. You will complete this outside of class. It is due, with Part 1, on March 6 @1159 PM EST. Email it to me at khanzali@syr.edu. Follow the steps on the next few pages to navigate your empirical research day on March 4. (I'm restating in case you forgot: follow the steps below).**

Read this definition:
Empirical research is when the research conducts their own original research to answer a research question. Usually this is done "in the field" or on location, which is what you'll be doing. Use empirical research methods–take either a quantitative approach or a qualitative approach–to do your own original research for this project.

Answer this question:
Based on your stakeholders research, what is your research question or hypothesis for your empirical research? Why's your study timely (Kairos) and important (exigence)? Write your answer in the space provided.

Choose an option for empirical research:

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OPTIONS

Try quantitative research

- Design a survey; get answers to your questions; aggregate data to find trends, patterns, and meaning.
- *Tips: don't include questions that will confirm your biases; do incorporate many people into the sample size, and be careful about convenience sampling – if you just interview people who are nearby you, then you'll miss out on a lot!*
- Watch a short how-to video here:
  Methods 101
  What is Empirical Research?
- Try Google Forms Survey Monkey (all free)...search online for other ones too!

Try qualitative research

- **Do an Ethnography**
  - observe a community; note what you see; derive meaning or new questions from that experience. Ethnographies can study online spaces too, it doesn't have to be in person only.
  - Watch a short how-to video here: https://youtu.be/Kan7962wtgs

- **Conduct an Interview (If you do conduct an interview, then you're only allowed to conduct 1 interview.)**
  - Meet with an expert (professor or industry professional) or "person on the street";
  - pose a set of close-ended questions (yes, no answers, fact-finding questions); pose a set of open-ended questions (questions that will lead to insight, unique perspectives, subjective answers, etc.)
  - Avoid convenience sampling–interviewing people just because they're nearby.

Resource: https://researchguides.library.syr.edu/libraryresearch

Design Your Research Plan:
Brainstorm data collection method, noting the pros and cons given your research question:

Method	*Pros*	*Cons*
Quantitative	Bigger and faster data collection	Cant guarantee data

Participant Observation: Can see real behavior and interactions | Time consuming and may be biased

Observation: Allows researcher to watch behavior naturally | Hard to know what people are thinking

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Interviews: Gives detailed opinions and personal perspectives | Small sample size and takes time

Now that you've noted the pros and cons, what research method/s are you going to go with? Describe why you want to use them. Why will it lead you to the answers you're looking for? How will you reach them? What are the ethical considerations you need to be aware of?

I used a quantitative method, which was a survey. I chose this method because it let me collect answers from a group of people in a short amount of time and compare their opinions about AI in education. This method helped me answer my research question because I could look for patterns in how people feel about AI, cheating, learning, and school rules.

Flesh out the details . . .
If you're doing a participant/observation style ethnography, in what ways will you engage with the community? If you're interviewing, what are your interview questions, who do you want to interview, and how will you connect with them? If you're observing, will you be looking/listening for specific things? How will you document your findings? Jot down a rough estimate of your timeline. Regardless of the kind of research that you do, *what questions will you be asking*?

I used a survey to collect my data. My survey asked people about their role, how familiar they are with AI tools, whether they use AI for school, and how they feel about AI in education. I asked questions about both the benefits and the risks of AI so I could get more balanced answers.

What is your role?

How familiar are you with AI tools like ChatGPT or Claude?

Have you used AI for academic purposes?

Do you believe AI improves academic productivity?

Is AI a helpful educational tool when used responsibly?

Does AI make students more dependent and less critical thinkers?

Should universities regulate AI usage?

What is the biggest benefit of AI in education?

What is the biggest risk of AI in education?

Conduct Your field research:
nting? Arrange your field notes as follows:
Analyze Research, Determine Results & Discussion:

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Information/Facts/Quotes	Questions/Analyses
21 people completed the survey.	The sample size is small but still shows general opinions.
Most respondents were undergraduate students.	The results mostly represent student perspectives rather than teachers.
Many respondents said AI is a helpful educational tool when used responsibly.	Students may see AI as a tool to support learning rather than replace it.
Several responses said AI helps with brainstorming and explaining difficult topics.	AI may help students understand complex material faster.
Some responses said AI saves time when working on assignments.	Students may use AI to manage heavy workloads.
Many respondents said AI can make students more dependent on technology	People worry that too much AI use may reduce critical thinking skills.

Analyze Field Research, Determine results. What did you notice? What patterns, repeated ideas, words, images did you observe? What didn't you notice? What might that suggest about the answer to your research question? What was the useful, notable data that you ended up collecting? What does it mean? What data was not useful? What does the data suggest? What did you notice? What patterns, repeated ideas, words, images did you observe? What didn't you notice? What might that suggest about the answer to your research question? ***Include examples, evidence, quotes, details from your field notes.*

I noticed a clear pattern: most people saw both benefits and risks in AI. A lot of respondents agreed that AI helps with schoolwork and learning, but they also worried that it can reduce originality and critical thinking.One major repeated idea was responsible use. Many answers showed that people are not fully against AI. Instead, they believe AI should be used with limits and guidelines.Another pattern was that many respondents believed AI will change education in a major way. This suggests that students and educators think AI is not temporary and will likely stay part of school and learning.

What's the answer to your research question? (Maybe the question changed or multiplied as you collected your data).

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My research question was about how people view AI in education and whether they see it as helpful or harmful.Based on my survey, the answer is that most people see AI as both helpful and risky. They believe AI can improve productivity and help students learn, but they also worry about cheating, overreliance, and less original work.

What's there to discuss: What's the takeaway? What did you learn through your research? What kinds of research should people do in the future about this topic? Is the method that you used useful? Should other people use it? What conclusions does your research lead you to? What's the answer to your research question? What's the takeaway? What did you learn through your research? What kinds of research should people do in the future about this topic? Is the method that you used useful? Should other people use it? What can scholars take away from your research, but also society in general? What life lessons can we learn from your project?

The main takeaway from my research is that AI in education is not a simple issue. Most people do not think AI is completely good or completely bad. They think it can help students, but only if it is used carefully.

I learned that many students and people in education already accept that AI will be part of the future. The bigger question is not whether AI should exist in school, but how it should be used.

In the future, more research could compare students and teachers more evenly, since my survey had many more student responses than teacher responses. Other researchers could also study whether AI changes actual learning outcomes over time.

My survey method was useful because it helped me collect many opinions quickly and find patterns. I think other people could use this method too, especially if they want to understand general opinions on a current issue.

A broader lesson from this project is that new technology usually brings both opportunities and problems. Society needs to learn how to use tools like AI in smart and ethical ways instead of only fearing them or fully trusting them.

NEXT PAGE PLEASE

Application: What from this field research will you incorporate into your hard conversation podcast or video? How will you apply any of this research to your hard conversation? Why?

I will use the survey results in my podcast to show that real students and people in education have mixed but thoughtful opinions about AI. I want to include the idea that AI is seen as useful for productivity and learning, but also risky because of cheating and dependence.

You must finish both parts 1 & 2 of this worksheet by March 6, 1159 PM EST. Choose one person from your group to email me your worksheet. Hyperlink is fine. Make sure I have access. No access, no credit. Send to khanzali@syr.edu